Product Management ~ Open Source

- Open source products & communities deserve the same intentionality as any roadmap
- The "*Open Source Way*" emphasizes principles like transparency, collaboration, and rapid iterative releases
- OS products have several stakeholders
  - users (who adopt the software)
  - contributors (one-time or regular code/documentation submitters)
  - customers (organizations buying related services or add-ons)
  - partners (ecosystem integrators)
  - competitors (others offering overlapping solutions)

Open Source Business Models

Support & services

Selling training, support contracts, or consulting. RedHat did this for Linux

Enterprise features

Core remains open, driving adoption, while paying customers get extra value.

Open Source Business Models

Hosted / Cloud offerings

Open source DBs are sold as hosted solutions

Dual or Custom licencing

Core remains open, driving adoption, while paying customers get extra value.

Managing an Open Source Product

Product Manager's motto:
"With great responsibility comes **NO** power"

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- Marketing & Adoption
  - Organic growth. No top-down sales.
- Feedback Loops
  - Listen to the whole community, not just your enterprise clients
- Rapid Iteration
- Product Strategy

Knowing foundational concepts

Product Manager's motto:
"With great responsibility comes **NO** power"

- Licensing
  - Permissive licenses (permissive like MIT, Apache 2.0)
  - Copyleft licenses like GNU General Public License
- Governance models
  - Founder-led (e.g. Elasticsearch began with a sole creator)
  - Backed by companies (e.g. Facebook's React)
- Stakeholders
- Upstream vs. Downstream
  - Upstream project (raw code)
  - Downstream products (commercial distributions or services)

Why Closed-Software PMs should care about Open Source

- Technology stack - every software now includes OSS components
- Innovation - open-source projects often lead industry trends
- Talent & ecosystem - many developers prefer OSS work
- Business strategy - Practices like open bug tracking, transparent roadmaps, and community-style feedback loops often come from OSS culture

Stats to care

- McKinsey research - 60% of decision-makers report lower costs with open-source AI tools
- CNCF data - many organizations plan to develop most new applications on Kubernetes-based platforms within 5 years
- Linux runs 96% of servers.
- WordPress powers 43% of websites.

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